

B17 REVIEW
By Dan Poorman

We all know the reputation the TRS-80 has for cassette loading problems. Especially us Level II folk. So, when I first heard about B17, it sounded like a dream come true!

Yes, it works. Quite well, as a matter of fact, and it does save a heck of a lot of time. B17 is a bit of software magic that costs \$25.00 and makes reading and writing to tapes quite a bit faster than the 500 baud rate that we're used to. As a matter of fact, the 'b' in B17 stands for BAUD, and the '17' indicates 1700 baud; over three times faster than our usual 500 baud rate. ABS Suppliers (the originators of B17) actually claim the program operates at 2125 baud, the highest rate that can be accommodated by the TRS-80 electronics. I didn't find any reason not to believe it.

I'll admit that I can't really measure the baud rate accurately, but I can tell you this much: Using B17, programs--both SYSTEM and BASIC--load in one third of the time with no problems at all. My modified Radio Shack Editor/Assembler loads in 44 seconds when under B17 control. Invasion will load in approximately 73 seconds, compared to it's usual 201 seconds. Before, my RSM-2 took 87 seconds, now it zooms into memory in about 27 seconds. Sargon zips into memory in just 68 seconds, compared to it's standard two minute and 38 second time.

Like everything else in this world that's good, there is a small price to pay (and I'm not referring to the \$25.00, either); B17 is no exception. If your TRS-80 has the XRX-2 cassette loading modification by Radio Shack, you'll have to bypass it in order for B17 to work. It's not difficult at all to do, it just means breaking the seal on your machine--a move that does not impress Radio Shack service folks, should you ever need service on your computer.

If your computer does NOT have the modification, B17 is strictly a software routine.

I do have the XRX-2 modification, and did have to bypass it. Installing the switch took me about 10 minutes, and is quite simple to do, following the instructions that come with the program. After that, duck soup. The program works beautifully loading and writing tapes at high speed, and if I don't use B17, it's just a matter of throwing the switch (I installed) to the opposite position. This move activates the XRX-2 modification once again, and I can load 500 baud tapes nicely.

The B17 program requires a SYSTEM load, the file name being 'B17'. The cassette comes complete with various

modules for loading both BASIC and machine language programs, and for machines with up to 48K of memory. I doubt that anyone would have 48K of RAM and not have disc, but the lads at ABS have a program for everyone.

At first, you'll see the familiar asterisks blinking up in the corner. When it shifts into high gear, you'll see, instead of the asterisks, an 'I' and an 'O' with a row of arrows in between. When B17 is inputting, the arrows will be pointing and moving towards the 'I'. When outputting, exactly the opposite. Neat touch, I think.

After duping the modules you need--in my case, 16K BASIC and high and low memory system--you are ready to convert your programs.

In BASIC, you set memory size to 31750 and load the BASIC B17 module. Then load the BASIC program. After loading the BASIC program, list it to make sure it loaded correctly. ANOTHER IMPORTANT NOTE: If the program is long, DO NOT run it! B17 takes up a little over 1K of memory, and you might not have enough room for RUNning, if the program has any arrays or needs a lot of string space. Once the program is loaded, slip a new tape into the recorder, push both the PLAY and RECORD buttons, type SAVE "filename", and you're on your way. After a short 500 baud pre-loader (this is written onto every B17 produced tape) you'll see the B17 verifier in the upper right hand corner, with the arrows pointing and moving towards the 'O' for output.

Once the program has been converted, you can verify it by typing 'LOAD?' in BASIC or using the 'V' command in machine language.

One of the nicest things about the program, I feel, is the LOAD AND GO option for system tapes. When you use the SYSTEM module, you can tell it the execute address, and when it is finished loading the program executes automatically!

Are there any negative points? Yes. My Adventure program--one that takes over four minutes to load and needs B17 badly--is too long to fit in my 16K machine along with the module to convert it. If I had 32K, there wouldn't be any problem, but I don't.

Other considerations, both good and bad: The program does not support a filename search, although it requires one to be input, even for the first program on the tape. When using B17 even without the XRX-2 modification, the level of the recorder is non-critical. You can always tell if there is a loading problem by watching the arrows up in the corner.

I guess the big question about any software is whether or not it's worth the price. In this case, you have a

program that you will undoubtedly use every single time you load or write a program to or from tape. True, it will set you back \$25.00, but that's beans compared to the purchase of a disc drive and interface expansion. B17 is neither as fast nor as versatile as disc, since it won't support data files, but it is certainly an improvement over the normal TRS-80 computer's cassette input and output.

Before closing, I will also pass along that ABS Suppliers tells me they'll soon be releasing a 'B29' that will allow the Editor/Assembler to read and write at the 1700 baud rate. That will bear watching for, as it just might make Assembly Language programming for the TRS-80 Level II more enjoyable, instead of an exercise in patience.

(B17 is available from TAS, or can be ordered directly from ABS Suppliers, P.O. Box 8297, Ann Arbor, MI 48107--Kos.)

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